Vakil.app — Product Requirements Document

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1. Overview

Vakil.app is a dark-first mobile app that lets a single advocate track every case, hearing date, client, document, note and fee in one place, entered manually, without a diary or WhatsApp threads.

Problem. Indian advocates juggle 30 to 200+ live matters across multiple courts. Next dates live in paper diaries, cause-list screenshots and memory. A missed date means an adjournment cost, an ex-parte order or an unhappy client. Existing tools are web-first, cluttered, or built for law firms rather than the solo practitioner.

Vision. The advocate opens the app at 9 AM and in 5 seconds knows: which matters are listed today, in which court, at what stage, and what is pending for each.

Product principle. One user (the advocate), one job (never lose track of a case), zero clutter. All data is entered manually in v1; court-data auto-fetch (eCourts / CNR) is a later phase.

2. Goals, non-goals and success metrics

Goals (v1)

1. Zero missed hearings: every case has a visible next date and a reminder.
2. Add a complete case in under 90 seconds.
3. Find any case in under 5 seconds (search by case no., party, client, court).
4. Record a hearing outcome and the next date in under 30 seconds, right outside the courtroom.
5. A premium, calm, dark-first interface the advocate is proud to show a client.

Non-goals (v1)

- Multi-user, juniors, clerks or firm accounts (single entity: the advocate).
- Client-facing login or portal.
- Auto-fetch from eCourts, cause-list scraping, OCR of orders.

- Billing invoices, GST, accounting.
- Web app (mobile only: Android first, iOS same codebase).

Success metrics

Metric	Target (90 days after launch)	How measured
Cases added per active advocate	25+	`cases` row count per user
Hearings with a next date set	95% of active cases	cases where `next_hearing_at` is not null
Time to add a case	under 90 s median	client event `case_create_started` to `case_created`
Time to record outcome	under 30 s median	`hearing_update_started` to `hearing_updated`
Day-7 retention	60%	opens on day 7 / sign-ups
Reminder open rate	40%	push opened / push sent
Crash-free sessions	99.5%	crash reporting

3. Target user: the advocate

The app has exactly one entity: the **Advocate**. Clients, opposing parties and courts are records the advocate creates, never app users.

Primary persona: Adv. Rohan Mehta, 31, independent litigator, Ahmedabad

Attribute	Detail
Practice	Civil, criminal, family and cheque-bounce (NI Act 138) matters
Courts	City Civil Court, Metropolitan Magistrate courts, Family Court, occasional High Court
Caseload	60 to 120 live matters, 4 to 12 listed per day

Attribute	Detail
Device	Mid-range Android, often on mobile data inside court premises
Current tools	Paper diary, WhatsApp self-chat, photos of orders in gallery
Context of use	Corridors, between matters, one-handed, in a hurry, low signal

Jobs to be done

- When I start my day, I want to see today's listed matters by court, so I am never in the wrong courtroom.
- When a matter is called and adjourned, I want to log the outcome and next date in seconds, so my diary is always correct.
- When a client calls, I want to pull up their case instantly, so I sound prepared.
- When I prepare for tomorrow, I want each matter's last outcome and my notes, so I walk in ready.

Pain points to design against: tiny tap targets, slow forms, loss of data offline, cluttered dashboards, and bright screens in dim court corridors (hence dark-first).

4. Scope: MVP feature set

P0 ships in v1.0; P1 follows within 4 to 6 weeks; P2 is the later roadmap. Every feature works on data the advocate enters by hand.

#	Module	Feature	Priority
1	Auth	Phone OTP sign-in (email + password fallback), session persistence	P0
2	Onboarding	Profile setup: name, enrolment no., practice areas, primary courts	P0
3	Dashboard	Today's hearings, upcoming 7 days, stats (active, today, this week, disposed), quick actions	P0
4	Cases	Add (4-step form), list, search, filter, sort, detail, edit, change status, archive, delete	P0

#	Module	Feature	Priority
5	Hearings	Add hearing, record outcome + next date, hearing history timeline	P0
6	Clients	Add/edit client, contact via call/WhatsApp, linked cases	P0
7	Calendar	Month view with hearing dots, day agenda	P0
8	Reminders	Push the evening before + morning of a hearing (configurable)	P0
9	Settings	Dark / Light / System theme, notification times, profile, logout	P0
10	Notes	Rich-text-lite notes per case, pinned notes	P1
11	Documents	Upload PDF/image per case (Supabase Storage via API), preview, rename, delete	P1
12	Fees	Agreed fee, payments received, balance per case	P1
13	Tasks	To-dos per case with due date (e.g. file reply, collect vakalatnama)	P1
14	Global search	One search across cases, clients, notes	P1
15	App lock	Biometric / PIN lock	P1
16	Export	PDF diary for a date range, CSV export	P2
17	eCourts	Fetch case status by CNR	P2
18	Team	Juniors / clerks with roles	P2

5. User stories

Each story maps to FRS requirement IDs. Acceptance criteria live in the FRS.

ID	As the advocate, I want to…	So that…	FRS ref	Priority
US-01	sign in with my phone number and OTP	I don't manage another password	FR-AUTH-01..04	P0

ID	As the advocate, I want to…	So that…	FRS ref	Priority
US-02	set up my profile and main courts once	forms pre-fill and feel personal	FR-ONB-01..03	P0
US-03	see today's listed matters grouped by court	I go to the right courtroom	FR-DASH-01..03	P0
US-04	add a case with number, type, court, parties, client and next date	the matter is tracked from day one	FR-CASE-01..06	P0
US-05	search and filter cases by status, court, type, date	I find a matter in seconds	FR-CASE-07..10	P0
US-06	open a case and see stage, next date, last outcome, client	I'm prepared before it is called	FR-CASE-11..12	P0
US-07	record what happened at a hearing and set the next date	my diary is always up to date	FR-HEAR-01..05	P0
US-08	see a timeline of every past hearing	I can brief a client or senior quickly	FR-HEAR-06	P0
US-09	mark a case disposed, closed or archived	my active list stays clean	FR-CASE-13..15	P0
US-10	keep client details and call or WhatsApp them from the app	I contact clients without searching contacts	FR-CLI-01..05	P0
US-11	see a month calendar with hearing dots	I can plan leave and avoid clashes	FR-CAL-01..03	P0
US-12	get a reminder the evening before and morning of a hearing	I never miss a date	FR-NOTIF-01..04	P0
US-13	switch between dark and light themes	I can read comfortably anywhere	FR-SET-02	P0
US-14	write notes on a case	my arguments and points are in one place	FR-NOTE-01..04	P1

ID	As the advocate, I want to…	So that…	FRS ref	Priority
US-15	attach orders, petitions and photos	I carry the file in my pocket	FR-DOC-01..05	P1
US-16	track agreed fee and payments	I know what each client owes	FR-FEE-01..04	P1
US-17	add to-dos with due dates on a case	filings and follow-ups aren't forgotten	FR-TASK-01..04	P1

6. Design principles and visual direction

The look is "midnight courtroom": deep navy surfaces, one confident blue, soft gradients reserved for hero moments, and generous whitespace. The full token set (colors, type, spacing, components) lives in the FRS.

Principles

1. **Today first.** The home screen answers "what is listed today?" before anything else.
2. **Thumb-first.** Primary actions sit in the bottom 40% of the screen; tap targets are at least 48 x 48 dp.
3. **One accent.** Blue is the only brand color; status colors carry meaning, never decoration.
4. **Calm density.** Cards show 3 facts max (case title, court, next date); detail is one tap away.
5. **Forgiving.** Every destructive action asks for confirmation or offers Undo for 5 s; drafts auto-save.
6. **Fast in bad signal.** Optimistic UI, cached lists, clear offline banner.

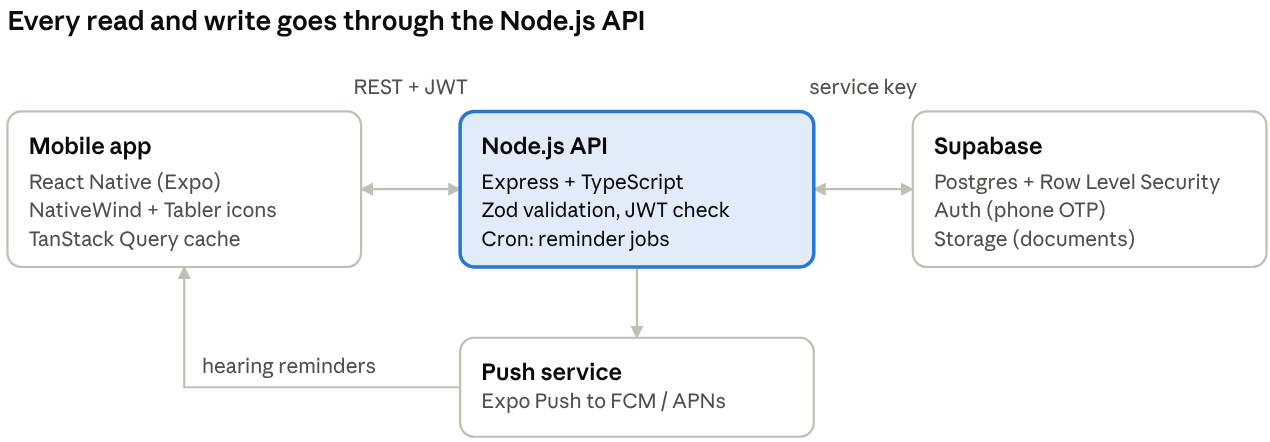
Theme

Item	Decision
Default theme	Dark (follows system only if the user picks System)
Primary	Blue 500 #3366FF (dark), Blue 600 #2350E6 (light)
Neutrals	Blue-tinted "Ink" scale, #0A101D to #FFFFFF

Item	Decision
Status	Success #22C55E, Warning #F59E0B, Error #EF4444, Info #0EA5E9, Adjourned #8B5CF6
Signature gradient	#3366FF to #6A4CFF (135°), used on hero card, primary FAB, onboarding
Font	Plus Jakarta Sans 400 / 500 / 600 / 700 / 800
Icons	Tabler Icons, outline 1.75 stroke, 24 px default; filled variant for active tab only
Corner radius	12 for inputs and buttons, 16 for cards, 28 for bottom sheets
Motion	200 ms ease-out for UI, 300 ms spring for sheets; respect Reduce Motion

7. Tech stack and architecture

The mobile app talks only to our Node.js REST API; the API alone holds the Supabase service key, validates every request and owns business rules such as reminder scheduling.



System architecture · app, API, Supabase, push

Layer	Choice	Notes
Mobile	React Native + Expo (SDK latest), TypeScript	Android first, iOS from the same codebase
Styling	NativeWind (Tailwind for RN)	Tokens in `tailwind.config.js`, dark mode via `class` strategy
Navigation	Expo Router (file-based)	Bottom tabs + stack + modal sheets
Server state	TanStack Query	Caching, optimistic updates, offline-read
Forms	React Hook Form + Zod	Same Zod schemas shared with the API
Icons	Tabler Icons (`@tabler/icons-react-native`)	Outline 1.75 stroke
Font	Plus Jakarta Sans via `expo-font`	Weights 400 to 800
Backend	Node.js 20 LTS + Express, TypeScript	REST `/api/v1`, JSON, Swagger docs
Database	Supabase Postgres	RLS on all tables, `advocate_id` on every row
Auth	Supabase Auth (phone OTP, email fallback)	API verifies the Supabase JWT on each call
Files	Supabase Storage, private bucket	Upload via API-issued signed URLs
Notifications	Expo Notifications + node-cron job	Evening-before and morning-of reminders
Hosting	API on Render / Railway; Supabase cloud (Mumbai region)	Low latency for India

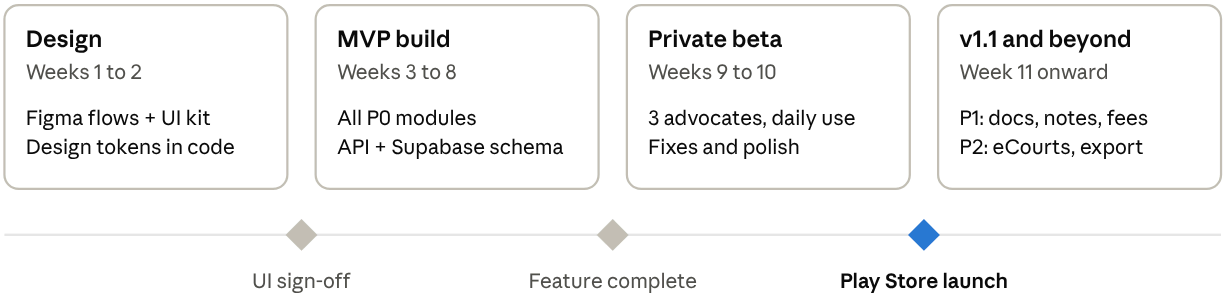
8. Non-functional requirements

Area	Requirement
Performance	Cold start under 2.5 s on a mid-range Android; list scroll at 60 fps; API p95 under 400 ms
Offline	Last-synced cases, hearings and clients readable offline; writes queued and retried; offline banner shown
Security	HTTPS only; JWT on every API call; RLS so an advocate can read only their rows; tokens in SecureStore; signed URLs expire in 10 min
Privacy	Client data is legally privileged: no analytics on content fields, no third-party sharing, account deletion removes all data within 30 days (DPDP Act 2023)
Reliability	Daily Supabase backups; reminder job is idempotent and logs every send
Accessibility	WCAG 2.2 AA contrast in both themes; Dynamic Type up to 130%; screen-reader labels on every icon button; 48 dp targets
Localization	English v1; dates DD MMM YYYY, IST; INR currency format; strings externalized for Hindi / Gujarati later
Compatibility	Android 9+, iOS 15+; phones 360 to 430 dp wide
Observability	Crash reporting (Sentry), API request logs, reminder delivery metrics

9. Release plan, risks and open questions

The proposed plan reaches a Play Store launch in about 10 weeks, gated on a private beta in which your friend and two peers use the app daily.

Four phases take Vakil.app from design to Play Store launch



Release roadmap · 4 phases, 3 gates

Beta exit criteria: 30+ real cases entered per beta user, zero missed hearings caused by the app, no P0 bugs open.

Risks

Risk	Impact	Mitigation
Manual entry feels slow, adoption drops	High	4-step form with smart defaults, remembered courts, "Add another" after save
Reminder not delivered (battery savers on Android)	High	Two reminders (evening + morning), in-app Today list, guide to disable battery optimisation
Weak signal in court premises	Medium	Offline read cache + queued writes
Sensitive client data leak	High	RLS, API-only access, private storage bucket, no content analytics
Scope creep into firm features	Medium	Single-entity rule enforced in PRD; team features parked in P2

Open questions

- [ ] Which courts and case types should ship as default pick-lists for Gujarat?
- [ ] Free forever, or a paid tier after the beta?
- [ ] Should a case support multiple clients (co-petitioners) in v1? (FRS assumes yes)
- [ ] Exact reminder times: default 8 PM day before and 8 AM same day?